



For Your MP3-Ears Only

Can see me through the knight-in-shining-armour

I don't like to wear a mini-skirt. Am not a cross-dresser like Freddie Mercury. But *I Want to Break Free* with my MP3-player. I certainly don't mean like a drag-queen singing out of iTunes, but freedom with true drag-and-drop. For an MP3-player is nothing but a flash or hard disk slapped together with headphones. When connected to a computer, an MP3-player should therefore show up as nothing more than a simple, empty hard disk. But that does not happen.

Mrs Digital Doubt FireWire

Your MP3-player insistently takes on an alter-ego, more like Mrs Digital Doubt FireWire nagging her own children. You can't rip, burn, copy, download, or share files without this disapproving nanny wagging her finger at you. Even worse, this *Chachi* 420 goads you to visit its online stores to purchase music files injected with DRM. That's Digital Rights Management, or Digital Restrictions Management, depending on how you wish to skin this *Cat in the Hat*. If you don't want DRM music, you could buy original audio CDs and rip them, or pay a premium to

"All this makes me lose more hair than Sinead O' Connor"

get DRM-free tracks from online stores. Nevertheless, the MP3-management software running on your computer, for example, iTunes for Apple iPods, still keeps track of your collection, your playing habits, your tastes in music, favourites, and more. All this makes me lose more hair than Sinead O' Connor.

This MP3-management software has both you and your MP3 player completely under its spell. You cannot manage tracks without it. Even if you use non-Apple MP3 players, they install some software on your PC to handle the device, or need a transfer protocol to give you the illusion of drag-and-drop. Microsoft created the Media Transport Protocol (MTP) which sacrifices some freedom for cheap convenience. Unfortunately, MTP is now supported by all the major players, including Creative, iRiver, Philips, Nokia, and others.

You might think such software and protocols are for Windows or Mac users. Unfortunately, Linux too needs them, and despite that, consider yourself lucky if your device works at first go. Apple's iPods need GTKPod or Rhythmbox, among a few other choices. Devices by Creative need Gnomad. Look at how complicated it is to make Creative's Zen X-Fi work under Linux: bit.ly/ZenXi-Fi-Linux. Resentfully, Philips has taken the

muft and *mukt* software SongBird and bundled it in to support its devices, but only under Windows. The developer community immediately forked SongBird to create an unofficial version for Linux. Finally, no matter what device you buy, all need MTP installed separately on your machine. Shoving video in and out of any personal device is an even more difficult task if you choose not to use proprietary software.

Where the Streets Have No Name

"I have run, I have crawled, I have scaled these city walls... These city walls, only to be with you, But I still haven't found what I'm looking for." After trawling through streets and gadget shops across India for two years, I have yet to find a branded device that works with the simplicity you and I crave. However, I have found a few ingenious solutions along with my gadget-friend, who goes by the clever nickname, *Dal Makhni*.

- The greatest iPod-killer is the USB-thumbdrive. Costs exponentially less than an iPod, has as much capacity as you want, and allows drag-and-drop music and folders at will. Playback using car-stereos, home-stereos, amplified-speaker systems, home LCD and LED TV screens, and even digital photo frames that offer a USB port.
- For personal listening while jogging or out on a limb, get a cheap, unbranded Chinese-made player. The MP3-codec on most is surprisingly good, especially when paired with good headphones. Alternatively, you can also use a chic mobile phone, managing and storing all your music on its removable memory-card.
- My ultimate solution: For almost the price of an iPod Classic, get a Linux-powered Netbook with a generously-large hard disk. Just use high quality headphones. Additionally, an audio-cable connects it to the rest of your gear. Netbooks obviously have features that far outclass iPod Classics or Archos devices at similar price-points. Anyway, time for me to go practice Shakira's moves on *Waka-Waka*. If she could dance for Africa's freedom, I could dance like *Zorba, the Greek* for our digital freedom. Now if only I could get those lyrics that're on the tip of my tongue 

About Niyam

Inspired by the vision of Osho. Copyright August 2010: Niyam Bhushan. freedomyugs@gmail.com. First published in LinuxForYou magazine. Verbatim copying, publishing and distribution of this article is encouraged in any language and medium, so long as this copyright notice is preserved. In Hindi, 'muft' means 'free-of-cost', and 'mukt' means 'with freedom'